

Cheating, Self-sabotage

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Jul 05, 2026 · Watch: https://www.youtube.com/shorts/GGe__0BLQM8 Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter argues that cheating — on a partner or a diet — is ultimately self-sabotage because the dopamine hit from novelty permanently dulls your enjoyment of whatever you already have.

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Dopamine and Novelty: Why Cheating Feels Good 0:00

- Brandon opens by stating he doesn't cheat on his girlfriend — but not because he's a "nice guy"
 - The real reason is understanding how dopamine works against you
- **Novelty is one of the biggest dopamine triggers** in the brain
 - The excitement comes from something being new, not from it being objectively better
- This explains a puzzling pattern he points out: when guys cheat, the other woman is almost never as attractive as their girlfriend
 - "Very seldom is the girl as hot as his girl"
 - People around them wonder, "Why is he cheating?" — the answer isn't attraction, it's dopamine from novelty

How Cheating Backfires on You 0:21

- After cheating, going back to your girlfriend produces less dopamine than before
 - Your brain has now experienced a novelty spike it can't replicate with a familiar partner
 - The result: you like your girlfriend less — not because she changed, but because your dopamine baseline shifted
- "Your girl can't compete with that" — the novelty spike is a chemical reaction, not a reflection of real value
- Framing: cheating is self-sabotage disguised as pleasure
 - You don't gain something; you damage your ability to enjoy what you already had

The Same Principle Applies to Diets 0:21

- Brandon draws a direct parallel to dietary cheating (cheat meals / breaking a diet)
 - The dopamine spike from forbidden or novel food works the same way
 - After the cheat, your regular healthy food feels even less satisfying than it did before
- Core principle: any time you chase a novelty-driven dopamine spike, you lower your baseline enjoyment of the ordinary
- "When you cheating, you really cheating yourself — either on your diet or your relationship or anything"

The Takeaway: Be Careful with Your Dopamine 0:27

- The practical conclusion: guard what spikes your dopamine deliberately
 - Chasing novelty in relationships or food erodes satisfaction with your real, everyday life
- "You got to be real careful. You got to keep that on" — implying you need to stay conscious of this dynamic before acting on impulse

The biggest insight: cheating doesn't add pleasure to your life — it subtracts it by making normal things feel worse afterward.